

Word family: **play / plays / played / playing / player / playful / playfully / playfulness / playmate / playground**

Base word: play

Past tense: played

Past participle: played

Related forms: player, playful, playfully, playfulness

Useful family extensions: playmate, playground, gameplay, role-play

Useful expressions / extensions: play with, play a game, play a sport, play music, play a role, play a part, play a character, play a trick, at play

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞) / related adjective and noun family (相關形容詞及名詞)

Your sentence:

> “He can spend hours **playing with Lego**...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **play** means:

> **to spend time doing something enjoyable for amusement, especially with toys, games, imagination, or physical activity**

Leo is using Lego for fun and imaginative activity.

繁體中文： ** **為了娛樂、樂趣或想像而進行活動；玩；玩耍

**中文翻譯： **

> “He can spend hours playing with Lego...”

「他可以花幾個小時**玩 Lego**.....」

Here:

play with Lego = 用 Lego 玩耍、拼砌和進行想像活動

1. **play = engage in enjoyable activity (玩耍) — 玩；玩耍**

This is the exact core sense in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

> “He can spend hours ****playing with Lego****.”

「他可以花幾個小時****玩 Lego****。」

Practice 2

> “The children are ****playing**** outside.”

「孩子們正在外面****玩****。」

Practice 3

> “Leo loves to ****play**** after school.”

「Leo 放學後很喜歡****玩耍****。」

****play = 為了娛樂、樂趣或消遣而進行活動****

2. ****play with + toy/object (玩某物) — 玩 ; 玩弄****

A very common pattern.

Practice 4

> “She was ****playing with**** a toy car.”

「她正在****玩玩具車****。」

Practice 5

> “The child likes ****playing with**** blocks.”

「那個小朋友喜歡****玩積木****。」

****play with something = 把某物當作娛樂、遊戲或想像活動的一部分****

3. ****play with + person (和某人玩) — 和.....玩 ; 一起玩耍****

Practice 6

> “He likes ****playing with**** his cousins.”

「他喜歡**和表兄弟姊妹一起玩**。」

Practice 7

> “The younger child asked Leo to **play with** him.”

「那個年紀較小的小朋友叫 Leo **和他一起玩**。」

play with someone = 與某人一起進行遊戲或娛樂活動

4. **play a game (玩遊戲) — 玩 ; 進行遊戲**

Practice 8

> “Let’s **play a game**.”

「我們來**玩個遊戲**吧。」

Practice 9

> “They **played** a board game after dinner.”

「他們晚飯後**玩了一個桌上遊戲**。」

play a game = 參與有規則或娛樂目的的遊戲

5. **play a sport (做 / 參與運動) — 打 ; 踢 ; 進行**

A major collocational use.

Practice 10

> “He **plays football** every weekend.”

「他每個週末都**踢足球**。」

Practice 11

> “She **plays tennis** at school.”

「她在學校**打網球**。」

****play + sport = 參與某項球類或遊戲型運動****

The Chinese verb changes naturally by sport:

* play football = 踢足球

* play tennis = 打網球

* play basketball = 打籃球

6. ****play = compete in a game/sport (比賽) — 比賽 ; 對賽****

Practice 12

> “Our team ****plays**** theirs tomorrow.”

「我們隊明天會和他們****比賽****。」

Practice 13

> “Who are you ****playing**** this weekend?”

「你們這個週末會和誰****對賽****？」

****play + opponent = 在比賽中與某人 / 某隊對抗****

This is common in sports English.

7. ****play = perform music on an instrument (演奏) — 彈奏 ; 演奏****

A major separate meaning.

Practice 14

> “She ****plays the piano****.”

「她會****彈鋼琴****。」

Practice 15

> “He ****played**** the guitar at the party.”

「他在派對上****彈結他****。」

****play + instrument = 用樂器演奏音樂****

8. ****play = produce recorded music/audio/video (播放) — 播放****

A major technology/media sense.

Practice 16

> “Can you ****play**** the song again?”

「你可以再****播放****那首歌嗎？」

Practice 17

> “The video won’t ****play****.”

「這段影片無法****播放****。」

****play = 使錄音、影片或數碼媒體開始播放****

9. ****play = perform a piece of music (演奏樂曲) — 演奏****

Practice 18

> “The band ****played**** my favourite song.”

「樂隊****演奏了****我最喜歡的歌曲。」

Practice 19

> “She ****played**** a short piece on the piano.”

「她用鋼琴****演奏了一小段樂曲****。」

****play + song/piece = 演奏某首樂曲 / 歌曲****

10. ****play = act a character/role (扮演) — 飾演；扮演****

A major dramatic/theatrical meaning.

Practice 20

> “She **played** the queen in the school play.”

「她在學校話劇中**飾演皇后**。」

Practice 21

> “He **plays** a doctor in the film.”

「他在電影中**飾演一名醫生**。」

play + character/role = 在戲劇、電影或表演中扮演某個人物

11. **play a role/part = have a function/influence (發揮作用) — 扮演角色；發揮作用**

A major figurative extension.

Practice 22

> “Parents **play an important role** in a child’s development.”

「父母在孩子成長中**扮演重要角色**。」

Practice 23

> “Luck **played a part** in the result.”

「運氣在結果中也**發揮了一定作用**。」

play a role/part = 在某件事情中具有某種功能、影響或重要性

This is not theatrical in literal meaning, although it develops from that idea.

12. **play = pretend / engage in make-believe (扮演遊戲) — 假裝；扮演**

Very relevant to children.

Practice 24

> “The children **played** astronauts.”

「孩子們**扮成太空人玩**。」

Practice 25

> “They were **playing** doctors.”

「他們正在**玩扮醫生的遊戲**。」

play + role/activity = 在想像遊戲中假裝自己是某種人或處於某種情境

This connects especially well to Leo turning the living room into a space station or jungle.

13. **play = move/use something idly (把玩) — 擺弄 ; 把玩**

A different use of **play with**.

Practice 26

> “He **played with** his pen during the meeting.”

「他開會時一直**把玩著原子筆**。」

Practice 27

> “She nervously **played with** her hair.”

「她緊張地**撥弄自己的頭髮**。」

play with something = 不斷輕輕碰、移動或擺弄某物，通常沒有明確目的

This is different from children's play.

14. **play with an idea (考慮想法) — 玩味 ; 考慮**

A figurative extension.

Practice 28

> “We are **playing with the idea** of moving.”

「我們正在**考慮搬屋這個想法**。」

Practice 29

> “The designer **played with** several different concepts.”

「設計師**嘗試 / 玩味**了幾個不同概念。」

play with an idea = 暫時、靈活地考慮或嘗試某個想法，而未正式決定

15. **play with words/language** (玩文字) — 玩味文字；運用文字效果

Practice 30

> “The poet likes to **play with words**.”

「那位詩人喜歡**玩味文字**。」

Practice 31

> “The advertisement **plays with language** in a clever way.”

「這個廣告很巧妙地**玩弄 / 運用語言效果**。」

play with words/language = 有創意地運用雙關、聲音、意思或文字形式

16. **play a trick/joke on someone** (捉弄) — 惡作劇；捉弄

Practice 32

> “The children **played a trick on** their teacher.”

「孩子們對老師**惡作劇**。」

Practice 33

> “Someone **played a joke on** him.”

「有人**捉弄**了他。」

play a trick/joke on someone = 故意用小把戲或欺騙方式捉弄某人，通常為了好玩

17. **play = behave strategically/manipulatively (耍手段) — 操弄 ; 玩弄**

A more figurative branch.

Practice 34

> “He knows how to **play the system**.”

「他很懂得如何**鑽制度漏洞 / 操弄制度**。」

Practice 35

> “She felt that he was **playing games** with her.”

「她覺得他在**跟她耍心機 / 玩心理遊戲**。」

****play = 利用規則、情況或別人的情感來取得某種效果****

Context matters; this can be negative.

18. **play it safe (保守行事) — 採取穩妥做法**

A common fixed expression.

Practice 36

> “Let’s **play it safe** and leave early.”

「我們**穩妥一點**，提早出發吧。」

Practice 37

> “He decided to **play it safe**.”

「他決定**採取較保守穩妥的做法**。」

****play it safe = 選擇風險較低、較保守的做法****

19. **play fair (公平行事) — 公平競爭 ; 公正對待**

Practice 38

> “Everyone should **play fair**.”

「每個人都應該**公平競爭 / 公平行事**。」

Practice 39

> “If you want people to trust you, **play fair**.”

「如果你想別人信任你，就要**公平待人**。」

play fair = 按公平、誠實的規則行事

20. **play along** (配合；假裝同意) — 配合；順著做

A common phrasal extension.

Practice 40

> “I knew it was a joke, but I **played along**.”

「我知道那是玩笑，但我還是**配合著演下去**。」

Practice 41

> “She decided to **play along** with the story.”

「她決定**順著那個說法配合下去**。」

play along = 暫時接受 / 配合某個情境、計劃或假裝，即使自己未必真正相信

21. **play down** (淡化) — 淡化；低調處理

A useful phrasal extension.

Practice 42

> “The company tried to **play down** the problem.”

「公司試圖**淡化問題的嚴重性**。」

Practice 43

> “She **played down** her achievements.”

「她**淡化**了自己的成就。」

play down = 刻意令某事顯得沒那麼重要、嚴重或突出

22. **play up** (強調 / 使更突出 ; 搗蛋) — 強調 ; 突出 ; 鬧事

Multiple common uses.

Practice 44

> “The advertisement **plays up** the product’s simplicity.”

「廣告特別**強調**產品的簡單易用。」

Practice 45

> “The children were **playing up** all afternoon.”

「孩子們整個下午都在**鬧 / 不聽話**。」

play up = 強調某特點 ; 亦可在英式口語中指小孩或設備表現不正常 / 惹麻煩

This is a phrasal extension and context-dependent.

23. **play out** (發展到最後 / 演變) — 發展 ; 上演

Practice 46

> “We need to see how the situation **plays out**.”

「我們要看情況最後會如何**發展**。」

Practice 47

> “The argument **played out** in public.”

「這場爭論在公開場合**逐步展開**。」

play out = 某個情況、事件或衝突逐漸發展直到結果出現

24. **play = noun: children's activity (玩耍) — 玩耍；遊戲活動**

Now **play** functions as a noun.

Practice 48

> “Children learn through **play**.”

「孩子透過**玩耍**學習。」

Practice 49

> “Free **play** is important for young children.”

「自由**遊戲 / 玩耍**對年幼小朋友很重要。」

play = 為娛樂、探索、學習或想像而進行的活動

25. **play = theatrical work (戲劇) — 話劇；劇本作品**

A major separate noun meaning.

Practice 50

> “We watched a **play** at the theatre.”

「我們在劇院看了一齣**話劇**。」

Practice 51

> “Shakespeare wrote many **plays**.”

「莎士比亞寫了很多**戲劇作品**。」

play = 為舞台演出而創作的戲劇作品

26. **play = action in a sport/game (比賽動作 / 比賽過程) — 比賽；一段賽事動作**

Practice 52

> “That was an excellent **play**.”

「那是一個非常精彩的**比賽動作 / 戰術配合**。」

Practice 53

> “The referee stopped **play**.”

「球證叫停了**比賽**。」

play = 比賽進行本身，或比賽中的某個具體動作 / 戰術

Especially common in sports.

27. **play** = freedom of movement (活動餘量) — 鬆動量；活動空間

A technical/mechanical noun sense.

Practice 54

> “There is too much **play** in the steering wheel.”

「方向盤的**鬆動量**太大。」

Practice 55

> “The joint should have a little **play**.”

「這個接合位應該留有少量**活動空間**。」

play = 機械部件之間可自由移動的微小空間 / 鬆動量

This is a genuine technical sense.

28. **at play** = operating / having an effect (正在起作用) — 正在發揮作用

A useful formal expression.

Practice 56

> “Several factors are **at play**.”

「有幾個因素正在**發揮作用**。」

Practice 57

> “Different emotions were **at play**.”

「不同情緒都在**影響當時的情況**。」

****at play = 某種力量、因素或影響正在發揮作用****

This is figurative and fairly formal.

29. ****player = person who plays a game/sport (運動員 / 玩家) — 球員 ; 玩家****

Practice 58

> “She is a talented tennis **player**.”

「她是一位很有天分的網球**球員**。」

Practice 59

> “The game supports four **players**.”

「這個遊戲支援四名**玩家**。」

****player = 參與某項運動、遊戲或競賽的人****

30. ****player = musician (樂手) — 樂手 ; 演奏者****

Practice 60

> “He is an excellent guitar **player**.”

「他是一位出色的結他**樂手**。」

Practice 61

> “The orchestra includes several young **players**.”

「樂團中有幾位年輕**演奏者**。」

****player = 演奏某種樂器的人****

31. ****player = important participant/influential organization (重要參與者) — 重要角色 ; 主要參與者****

A major figurative extension.

Practice 62

> “The company is a major ****player**** in the market.”

「這間公司是市場上的****主要參與者 / 重要企業****。」

Practice 63

> “Several international ****players**** are involved.”

「有幾個國際上的****重要參與者****牽涉其中。」

****player = 在某個領域、行業或情況中有重要影響力的人 / 組織****

32. ****player = playback device (播放器) — 播放器****

Practice 64

> “I need a new media ****player****.”

「我需要一個新的媒體****播放器****。」

Practice 65

> “The music ****player**** stopped working.”

「音樂****播放器****壞了。」

****player = 用來播放錄音、影片或其他媒體的裝置 / 軟件****

33. ****playful = full of fun / joking (愛玩的 / 調皮有趣的) — 愛玩 ; 活潑調皮的****

A useful adjective.

Practice 66

> “Leo has a **playful** personality.”

「Leo 的性格很**愛玩、活潑調皮**。」

Practice 67

> “She gave him a **playful** smile.”

「她向他露出一個**帶點玩笑意味的笑容**。」

playful = 喜歡玩、開玩笑或以輕鬆有趣方式表現的

34. **playful** = light-hearted rather than serious (帶玩味的) — 輕鬆有趣的；帶玩味的

Practice 68

> “The design has a **playful** style.”

「這個設計風格很**活潑有趣 / 帶玩味**。」

Practice 69

> “The writer uses a **playful** tone.”

「作者使用了一種**輕鬆帶玩味的語氣**。」

playful = 不嚴肅、帶創意、幽默或遊戲感的

35. **playfully** = in a playful manner (開玩笑地 / 活潑地) — 調皮地；玩笑地

Practice 70

> “She **playfully** pushed him away.”

「她**開玩笑地**把他推開。」

Practice 71

> “He **playfully** pretended to be angry.”

「他**鬧著玩地**假裝生氣。」

****playfully = 以輕鬆、調皮、開玩笑的方式****

36. ****playfulness = playful quality (玩心 / 活潑感) — 調皮；玩味；愛玩的特質****

Practice 72

> “His ****playfulness**** makes children comfortable.”

「他的****活潑玩心****令小朋友感到自在。」

Practice 73

> “The room’s design has a sense of ****playfulness****.”

「房間的設計帶有一種****玩味和活潑感****。」

****playfulness = 喜歡玩、開玩笑、探索或以輕鬆創意方式表現的特質****

37. ****playmate = child/person someone plays with (玩伴) — 玩伴****

Practice 74

> “The two children became ****playmates****.”

「兩個小朋友成為了****玩伴****。」

Practice 75

> “He invited his ****playmate**** over.”

「他邀請他的****玩伴****來家裡。」

****playmate = 經常和某人一起玩耍的人，尤其指小孩****

38. ****playground = area for children to play (遊樂場) — 遊樂場****

Practice 76

> “The children are in the **playground**.”

「孩子們在**遊樂場**。」

Practice 77

> “The school built a new **playground**.”

「學校建了一個新的**遊樂場**。」

playground = 專供兒童玩耍、通常設有遊樂設施的地方

39. **gameplay** = way a game is played (遊戲玩法) — 遊戲玩法；操作體驗

A useful modern compound.

Practice 78

> “The game has simple **gameplay**.”

「這款遊戲的**玩法**很簡單。」

Practice 79

> “Good **gameplay** matters more than graphics.”

「好的**遊戲玩法 / 操作體驗**比畫面更重要。」

gameplay = 電子遊戲實際進行、操作和互動的方式

40. **role-play** = act out a role/situation (角色扮演) — 角色扮演

Practice 80

> “Students **role-played** a job interview.”

「學生進行了工作面試的**角色扮演**。」

Practice 81

> “The activity uses **role-play** to practise speaking.”

「這項活動透過**角色扮演**練習口語。」

****role-play = 扮演某種人物或情境，以練習、娛樂或模擬真實互動****

Important distinction: **play vs game**

**play**

can mean the general activity of playing.

**game**

is usually a specific structured activity with rules or goals.

> “Children learn through play.”

= 孩子透過玩耍學習。

> “They played a game.”

= 他們玩了一個遊戲。

So:

****play = activity****

****game = a particular structured activity****

Important distinction: **play vs have fun**

**play**

describes an activity.

**have fun**

describes the experience of enjoying yourself.

A child can ****play**** without necessarily having fun, and adults can ****have fun**** without literally playing.

Important distinction: **play vs play with**

play

can stand alone:

> “The children are playing.”

play with + person/object

names who/what is involved:

> “The children are playing with Lego.”

> “She is playing with her brother.”

Your passage uses **play with Lego**.

Important distinction: **play with a toy vs play with your hair**

Toy:

> **play with Lego**

= use it for fun/creative activity.

Hair:

> **play with your hair**

= repeatedly touch or fiddle with it.

Same construction, but different contextual meaning.

Important distinction: **play a sport vs do a sport**

English often uses **play** with competitive games/ball sports:

> play football

> play tennis

but often ****do**** with activities such as:

- > do yoga
- > do gymnastics

and ****go**** with many -ing activities:

- > go swimming
- > go skiing

This is mainly collocational.

Important distinction: **play music** vs **play a song******

**play music******

can mean:

- * perform music
- * cause recorded music to play

**play a song******

also can mean either.

Context resolves whether the subject is:

- * a musician
- * a device/person controlling playback

Important distinction: **play an instrument** vs **play music******

**play the piano******

= use the instrument to perform.

**play music******

may mean:

- * perform music

* play a recording

So **play music** is more ambiguous.

Important distinction: **play a role — literal vs figurative**

Literal:

> “He played Hamlet.”

= 他飾演 Hamlet。

Figurative:

> “Education plays an important role.”

= 教育發揮重要作用。

The figurative sense maps:

> dramatic role → function within a larger situation.

Important distinction: **play = children’s make-believe vs act**

play doctors

= children pretend to be doctors as a game.

act as a doctor

= perform the function of a doctor, possibly seriously.

So **play** signals imagination/pretence.

Important distinction: **play with an idea vs decide**

play with an idea

= consider it experimentally and without commitment.

decide

= reach a conclusion.

So playing with an idea is exploratory.

Important distinction: **play a trick vs lie**

play a trick

usually aims at surprise or amusement.

lie

means deliberately state something false.

A trick may involve deception, but the social intention is different.

Important distinction: **playful vs childish**

playful

often positive:

> fun, teasing, light-hearted.

childish

often negative:

> immature.

An adult can be **playful** without being **childish**.

Important distinction: **playful vs funny**

funny

= causes laughter.

playful

= behaves in a fun, teasing, light-hearted way.

Someone can be playful without being especially funny.

Important distinction: **player — sport vs market**

Sport:

> “a football player”

= 足球員

Business:

> “a major player in the industry”

= 行業中的重要參與者 / 大型企業

The business meaning is figurative.

Important distinction: **play — noun: play vs play — noun: drama**

Activity:

> “Children need play.”

= 孩子需要玩耍。

Drama:

> “We watched a play.”

= 我們看了一齣話劇。

These are genuinely distinct noun meanings.

Important distinction: **play vs performance**

play

can mean the act of participating/performing.

performance

focuses on how well someone carries out an activity or the event itself.

> “His play improved.”

in sport can mean how he performed.

> “His performance improved.”

is broader and more formal.

Important distinction: **at play vs playing**

playing

usually means literally engaging in play/game/music/etc.

at play

often means:

> a factor or influence is operating.

> “Several factors are at play.”

= 有幾個因素正在起作用。

So **at play** is an established figurative expression.

Family-extension note

Play is a very strong polysemy word.

Its major semantic centres include:

* **recreational activity** → children play

* **use toys / play with someone**

* **participate in games/sports**
 * **perform music**
 * **play media**
 * **act a character**
 * **perform a function** → play a role
 * **pretend / imaginative role-play**
 * **fiddle/manipulate** → play with your hair
 * **explore ideas** → play with an idea
 * **strategic/manipulative behaviour**
 * **noun: recreation**
 * **noun: drama**
 * **noun: sports action**
 * **technical mechanical play**

The family sweep adds:

* **player**
 * **playful**
 * **playfully**
 * **playfulness**
 * **playmate**
 * **playground**
 * **gameplay**
 * **role-play**

Because **play** is so construction-rich, the key is to distinguish genuine semantic shifts while not pretending every sport, instrument, or game collocation is a new meaning. That fits the manual's broad-search, conservative-splitting approach.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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play — recreational activity	為了娛樂、樂趣或消遣而進行活動
play with a toy/object	把某物當作娛樂、遊戲或想像活動的一部分
play with someone	與某人一起玩耍 / 進行遊戲活動
play a game	參與有規則或娛樂目的的遊戲
play a sport	參與某項球類或遊戲型運動
play an opponent	在比賽中與某人 / 某隊對抗
play an instrument	用樂器演奏音樂
play music/song	演奏音樂，或使錄音開始播放；依語境判斷
play media	使錄音、影片或數碼內容開始播放
play a character	在戲劇、電影或表演中扮演某人物
play a role/part	在某件事中具有某種功能、影響或重要性

play — make-believe	在想像遊戲中假裝自己是某種人物 / 處於某情境	
play with something — fiddle	沒有明確目的地反覆碰、擺弄或移動某物	
play with an idea	暫時、靈活地考慮或試驗某個想法	
play with words	有創意地運用文字、意思、聲音或雙關	
play a trick on	以小把戲或欺騙方式捉弄某人	
play the system/games	策略性操弄規則、情況或別人的反應	
play it safe	選擇風險較低、較保守的做法	
play fair	按公平、誠實的規則行事	
play along	暫時配合某情境、計劃或假裝	
play down	刻意淡化某事的重要性 / 嚴重性	
play up	強調某事；英式口語亦可指鬧事 / 出問題	
play out	某個情況或事件逐步發展至結果出現	
play — noun recreation	為娛樂、探索、學習或想像而進行的玩耍活動	
play — noun drama	為舞台演出而創作的戲劇作品	
play — sports noun	比賽進行本身或比賽中的具體動作 / 戰術	
play — mechanical	機械部件之間可自由移動的鬆動量 / 活動空間	
at play	某種力量、因素或影響正在發揮作用	
player — sport/game	參與運動、遊戲或競賽的人	
player — musician	演奏樂器的人	
player — industry	某領域中有重要影響力的人 / 組織	
player — device/software	播放音訊、影片或其他媒體的裝置 / 程式	
playful	愛玩、調皮、輕鬆有趣或帶玩味的	
playfully	以輕鬆、調皮、開玩笑的方式	
playfulness	愛玩、輕鬆、富創意或調皮的特質	
playmate	經常和某人一起玩耍的人	
playground	專供兒童玩耍的地方	
gameplay	電子遊戲實際操作、互動和進行的方式	
role-play	扮演人物 / 情境以練習、娛樂或模擬互動	

For your original sentence

> “He can spend hours ****playing with Lego****, drawing imaginary cities, or folding paper rockets...”

The exact meaning is:

****play = 為了娛樂和想像而進行活動****

and specifically:

> ****play with Lego****

= ****「玩 Lego，用 Lego 拼砌、創作和進行想像遊戲」****

This is not merely:

> ****touching or fiddling with Lego****

because the following sentence says he:

> “creates whole worlds around them.”

So Leo’s **play** is:

> recreational + imaginative + creative

rather than:

* **play football** = 踢足球

* **play the piano** = 彈鋼琴

* **play a character** = 飾演角色

* **play a video** = 播放影片

* **play a role** = 發揮作用

In the passage, it is the straightforward but rich **children’s recreational/imaginative play sense**.